

Siya Chhibber - Journalism Portfolio

Four Stories on a Crisis

Junior Journalists program

April to July 2026

THE NEWSROOM

Junior Journalists is a paid four-month reporting internship for Alameda County high school students. In my cohort, roughly 90 students applied for 30 positions. Reporters pitch their own stories in weekly editorial meetings, develop them with an assigned advisor, and revise through editorial review before publication.

THE BRIEF

Make the opioid crisis understandable to other young people: accurate enough to survive scrutiny, clear enough that a teenager finishes the piece.

MY ROLE

Reporter and sole author on all four pieces. I pitched each story, conducted research and source verification, secured and conducted the expert interview, and revised under editorial review before publication.

METHODS

Story pitching and editorial development; primary and secondary source research; peer-reviewed source verification; expert interviewing; policy analysis; revision; writing for a general audience.

MY PROCESS



The Articles

Four published pieces, each built around a different way of finding and testing a story.

Published in Pleasanton Weekly, Livermore Vine and DanvilleSanRamon.com

BEHAVIORAL SCIENCE

Changing habits to break addiction

April 13, 2026

Opened with David Sedaris quitting smoking after moving to Japan, then used behavioral research to examine how environment and cue disruption shape habit formation - and why willpower alone is a poor model for dependence.

Reporting challenge: translate mechanism into something a reader feels rather than studies.

CASE STUDY

Belief systems and opioid addiction

April 21, 2026

Examined how personal conviction intersected with medical decisions in the cases of Steve Jobs and Prince. I rebuilt the piece around independently sourced events and revised the framing to separate evidence from blame.

Reporting challenge: describe a causal sequence without indicting a faith.

EXPERT INTERVIEW

The depiction of addiction in cinema

July 12, 2026

An eight-question Q&A with Antonio Alfaro, who teaches film studies at Las Positas College, on portrayals of substance use from Reefer Madness to Euphoria, including glamorization, realism, narrative structure, and social responsibility.

Reporting challenge: the strongest answers came from asking about specific films, not the topic in general.

POLICY ARGUMENT

Beyond 'Just Say No'

July 26, 2026

Argued that evidence-based prevention should replace dated scare tactics, drawing on an APA longitudinal study, a Surgeon General designation, and a GAO report.

Reporting challenge: criticism only held if the evidence was stronger than readers' familiarity with the program.